# The Final Days of Dog-Baby

## By Mary O'Connell

*Some younger age "cut" suggestions are designated by parenthesis*

Mark and I were snuggled up on the couch, watching a little basketball, and I felt happy. Then we heard Beth screaming in the bathroom. She rushed out to us, waving the pregnancy-test stick in the air, yelling, "It's a cross, it's a cross."

It wasn't a cross, of course, it was an X. The X means you are pregnant.

I had been dreading this news. But God knows I'm a sucker for fun, so I hopped off the couch and ran in a circle around their feet as they jumped up and down, game-show style.

"A baby," Mark said.

"A baby," Beth said.

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## INTRODUCTION

*The birth of a baby affects everyone in the family: mom, dad, and siblings. But what about the family pet? Mary O'Connell explores the mind of a dog going through this traumatic change in "The Final Days ofDog-Baby" by Mary O'Connell.*

A fierce premonition of loneliness flooded my heart, and I slunk away from them, trying to steel myself against the love that would soon be taken so cruelly. I imagined myself staked in the back yard the following winter, parched and starving, gnawing ice chips from a dented water bowl. With their love for the baby, I would become a curiosity: "Why did we ever want this old thing? Dog-Baby, free to good home."

When I started to cry, they **(said)** "Give us some kisses, Dog-Baby, you big velvet schmutz." and I was happy again. Hey, I'm moody.

In the beginning I was Dahlia, named for the flowers on the patio: Legend has it that the day they brought me home from the kennel, I stretched my neck up to the terra-cotta pots, and smelled the flowers.

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Beth yelled, "Dahlia." Mark had reservations, and he was right, because the name never stuck. By the second day, enamored of my tight, round tummy, caramel-colored eyes and they cuddled me to their shoulders and called me Dog-Baby.

But my name has caused real pain for all of us. Recently, Mark and Beth had a dinner guest who told endless stories about her brilliant toddler. This was back when they believed the doctors who claimed they would never have a baby, and they both sat there with stiff smiles stretched across their faces. To break up the tension, I sprang out from my post under the kitchen table and started barking. The woman gaped at me with an expression of repulsed curiosity.
"Dog-Baby. So your dog's like your. . . baby."

When it was just the three of us again, Beth raged: "This is who we are, Mark. We're yuppies who treat our dog like a baby."

Mark tried to comfort her.

Anyway, Beth stormed out of the house and soon we heard the car rocketing down the street.

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Mark gave me a peanut-butter biscuit, then poured a juice glass. I held the biscuit in my mouth, watching him; I cannot eat on a nervous stomach. When I rested my head on his knee and sighed, Mark reached under the table and stroked my ears.

After some time, he raised his glass. "Here's to us, Dog-Baby." For as long as I can remember, I have been the Dog-Baby.

Strange how the days gallop past when you dread the future. It is the first Saturday in November, misty and gray, and Beth is eight months along. Mark is painting "the nursery," I'm relegated to the back yard for the morning--the beginning of the end. I peer through the planks in the fence and see Trixie, the dachshund who lives in the house behind us, skitter through her tiny dog-door.

"Trixie," I yell, "over here," and she runs across her yard and zips under the fence.

We sniff each other's butt, then kiss-kiss.

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"Trixie," I say, my lips quivering like Bette Davis, "if they forget to feed me when the baby comes, will you save your Snausages for me?"

"Aw, Dog-Baby, they won't forget to feed you! After Madison came, Sue and Campbell never forgot to feed me. They let my water dish go dry a time or two, but I just licked the shower floor, no problem!"

I shudder at this image. How can I expect her to understand? She was a pound dog and lived through atrocities before Sue and Campbell brought her home and made her perpetually grateful. But I have known only opulence: a king-size bed, organic biscuits, and love. Now that unhappiness looms ahead of me, I find myself more than a little ill-prepared.

"Dog-Baby, I know you've been sad about the little baby comin' and you have what I consider to be a classic fear of displacement. But I'm here to tell you: Buck up, buttercup! They'll still love you. When a baby comes, it just means the pack gets bigger!"

Sue calls out the kitchen window for Trixie to come home.

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"Okay, Trix," I sigh, "we'll be seeing you,"

"Not if I see you first, Dog-Baby," she says, flashing the smile that saved her from Death Row.

The bed shrinks as Beth gets bigger and bigger. Tonight, as I listen to the rain, I suffer from a kind of self-induced insomnia. Since time is my enemy, I keep my eyes open, trying to hold on to the day, watching the numbers slip past on the digital clock. Beth turns on her side, and spoons her body to mine. Pressed against my spine I feel the great weight of Beth's stomach, and then, movement, like a giant heart beating.

"The baby is kicking you, Dog-Baby."

And I'm thinking about how true that is, when Beth sits up in bed. "Holy Mother of God, I'd like a cigarette." *(Possible substitution for younger ages: "Oh my gosh, I need ice-cream.")*

Next thing you know she's slogging her big body out of bed and putting on slippers. I follow her.

I sit on the rug and watch her with disdain.

"Don't give me that look, Dog-Baby. I haven't had a cigarette for ages. I know it's disgusting; I don't know

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why I love it so much." *(Possible substitution for younger ages: I haven't had ice cream for ages.)*

It's chilly. Beth notices me shivering and takes a sequined sweater from the garbage bag of clothes destined for the Salvation Army. She buttons the top button of the sweater around my neck, arranging the arms of the sweater to look like human arms jutting out of my Dog-Baby body.

She just leans back and laughs. "Dog-Baby, you look just like a glamorous spinster aunt sitting at a soda fountain! Miss Prim!"

I've heard it all before.

And I prefer when she wants to watch "I Love Lucy" at 2 a.m. and we cuddle under a quilt on the couch. "See how Ricky loves Lucy, the look in his eyes?" And there are the night sounds of the house: the hiss of the furnace, the refrigerator's song, mice running in the walls, the perpetual drip of the kitchen faucet.

Beth takes a last drag on her cigarette *(Possible substitution for younger ages: Beth takes a last spoonful of ice-cream)*, and bursts into tears. I whimper along with

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her--it's my way. She's worried the baby will have six heads because she smoked a cigarette *(Possible substitution: She's worried the baby will have six heads because she had too much sugar;)* me, I'm sad our private late-night rendezvous are coming to an end.

The digital clock reads 8:10 when Mark walks into the bedroom carrying a blue blanket with white stars, and right away I know I slept through the whole deal.

The blanket is in front of my face.

"Smell, Dog-Baby."

This is what it says to do in the books. The books have a lot of crazy advice. It is upon us. Acceptance is the only choice. I sniff the dog blanket, Mark takes me in his arms and I feel his love, but it's like how you love an old aunt in a nursing home: Gosh, you were nice. We have a lot of really nice pictures of you.

Beth staggers in the door carrying a white baby carrier and the big, black diaper bag. Mark comes next, carrying the actual baby in a mint green blanket. I sit

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stoically, holding my head up but casting my eyes down, ever the brave coquette.

Beth winces as she bends down and lays her head on my bony shoulder. She bursts into tears. "Oh, Dog-Baby, it's like I haven't seen you in a million trillion years."

Which is the reception I've been hoping for. It's a relief when Mark sits on the couch and motions for me to join him. He pulls the blanket back from the baby's face and offers me a look.

"Here's the baby, Dog-Baby."

Well. He's nothing like the big, rubbery babies on TV. He is small and red and ancient-looking, a tiny guy in a panda outfit. As I gaze at him, I feel the weird miracle of it all, how odd it is that a body can produce another body.

The baby cries out, and Beth coos to it nervously as Mark caresses the baby's cheek with his quivering finger. They are afraid of this baby! This is something I never anticipated, and I can't help but feel a little smug, for certainly they were never afraid of me.

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The first night, I stand at the doorway as Mark and Beth climb into bed. The baby is sleeping in the bassinet on Beth's side of the bed. I chant to myself, "I am a dog," a mantra for the future, when Mark whispers, "Dog-Baby, do you need an engraved invitation get in the bed?" My heart leaps up, and I sail onto the bed, snuggle down between them.

Beth puts her finger to her lips and whispers, "I just wanted to make sure he was still breathing."

Of course, it's me who's in danger of falling into that final sleep, me who has the arthritis and poor circulation and iffy heart. But my ears are perfect; I hear each breath expanding in the baby's new lungs. I hope I live to see this baby grow into his childhood. I want to be stranded, say, in Antarctica, and have him make a solo journey to rescue me, as brave children do in the movies. But for now he is just a baby, living every second at the mercy of others. My brother.

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***Note – Full text of selection can be found on-line at***
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